EUROPE WON'T FIGHT AMERICA'S WAR

Against the backdrop of the Iran conflict, the ongoing war in Ukraine and unpredictable US policy under the Trump administration, the German, Italian and Spanish ambassadors to India outlined a Europe that is no longer uniformly dependent on Washington's strategic direction. "Europe suffers from this war, as the energy crisis will slow down our economies," said German ambassador Philipp Ackermann, while stating that there were elaborate plans to prevent Iran from getting nuclear weapons. He also expressed concern that the attention now shifts away from Russia's war on Ukraine, which Europe continues to view as a central security challenge. According to him, Berlin opposes nuclear proliferation but prefers negotiations over military action. It also opposes the US easing restrictions on Russian oil, as it can prolong the Ukraine conflict. Though the rising cost of oil hurts, Ackermann asserted, "Germany does not and will not buy Russian oil". A key concern for all three envoys was the absence of clarity on the war's endgame, making meaningful diplomatic intervention difficult.

Italian ambassador Antonio Bartoli introduced another common concern for all three. "There is a weakening of global organisations," he asserted. While reaffirming its deep-rooted ties with the US through NATO, Bartoli put the current moment as "a wake-up call for European strategic autonomy". He also pointed to tangible consequences of the conflict—rising inflation, energy insecurity and economic slowdown—while stressing that Italy has limited its role to defensive deployments and humanitarian efforts in the Gulf.

Juan Antonio March Pujol, the Spanish envoy, spoke out for strengthening multilateral institutions like the United Nations, so as "to fight in favour of peace and development". It warned that continued reliance on confrontation risks long-term instability, and highlighted the generational shift away from war. "No one from the young generation is in favour of war," he said. Spain, an open dissenter on the Iran war, also called for global cooperation over competition, positioning peace-building as the central priority in a volatile world.

Other than a call for peace, a common thread across the discussion was Europe's limited ability to influence the current conflict despite talking with all key



Photographs by HARDIK CHHABRA

DR PHILIPP ACKERMANN ▲
Ambassador of Germany to India

"Are European nations trying to solve this crisis? We don't know the endgame of this war—and without that clarity, diplomacy becomes difficult

All of a sudden, the war in Iran has shifted attention away from the Russian aggression in Ukraine. This is very concerning for us